

A dinner party in the apartment of Isaac Khalatnikov in Moscow, June 1971. Clockwise from left: Kip Thorne, John Wheeler, Evgeny Lifshitz, Isaac Khalatnikov, Khalatnikov's wife Valentina Nikolaievna, Vladimir Belinsky, and Khalatnikov's daughter Eleanora. [Courtesy Charles W. Misner.]

For a theoretical physicist it is more than embarrassing to admit a major error in a published result. It is ego shattering. I should know. In 1966 I miscalculated the pulsations of white-dwarf stars, and two years later my wrong calculations briefly misled astronomers into thinking that the newly discovered pulsars might be pulsating white dwarfs. My error, when found, was significant enough to figure in an editorial in the British journal *Nature*. It was a bitter pill to swallow.

Though errors like this can be shattering for an American or European physicist, in the Soviet Union they were far worse. One's position in the pecking order of scientists was especially important in the Soviet Union; it determined such things as possibilities for travel abroad and election to the Academy of Sciences, which in turn brought privileges such as a near doubling of one's salary and a chauffeured limousine at one's beck and call. Thus it was that the temptation to try to hide or downplay mistakes, when mistakes occur, was greater for Soviet scientists than for Westerners. And thus it was that Lifshitz's plea for help was impressive. He wanted no delay in disseminating the truth, and his manuscript was forthright: It confessed the error and announced that future editions of *The Classical Theory of*